

use the player with or without software. Without software, you can simply drag and drop files in the player.

Operating system compatibility

Almost all the players are compatible with latest versions of Windows. Most of these are plug-and-play type. However, there are players which need the proprietary software to be installed before use.

The Apple iPod touch comes with iOS 4.1 that enables new features like FaceTime video calling, multitasking, folders and Game Center.

Others

Currently, FM radio and audio-video recording are common in all the portable media players. With audio/video recording, you can record those class lectures and avoid taking tedious notes. Or be lauded for your memory and the meticulous minutes of the last

office meeting by simply recording the whole session.

There are many other features like high-definition playback, in-built camera, gaming and GPS. But remember, anything additional is likely to add to the price of the player. So go for these features only if you would really use them.

In audio features, you can look for the capability to drive external portable speakers and karaoke mode. The karaoke mode automatically reduces the volume of the original performer's vocals, allowing you to hear the backing audio easily. A handy bookmark function (as in Sony Walkman players) will let you create, add to or edit personalised playlists on the player itself.

The new range of Philips GoGear comes with an online forum and software called Philips Songbird which allows listeners to easily sync music, purchase songs, buy concert tickets, watch artist-related video on YouTube

and Flickr Photo, and access diverse information about artists.

Creative's ZEN X-Fi Style supports reading RSS feeds offline. So you can connect to your computer and download the latest happenings with ease.

In summary...

Look for premium features within your budget. The bare essentials are light weight, storage capacity for all the music and video content that you are likely to carry at a time, and a long battery life. Look for good headphones which come along with the player. These play a critical part in reproducing the music. Some players provide features like enhancing the MP3 sound quality to near-about CD-quality; for example, Philips players have 'full sound.'

Last but not least, go for a reputed brand providing warranty and good after-sales service. ●

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